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basis of certain forms of research and which is even the basis of the conjectures of those scholars who think that most of our learning is hard-wired into our brains. However, an episode is much harder to capture in a laboratory experiment and so the longer time frame actually casts doubt upon the idea that we are hard-wired before birth and places much more focus on learning from continuing conscious experiences through which we construct our biography. Experiences are both single events and elongated episodes and we learn from both.

Part 4: Experience as expertise

An expert is one who 'has extensive skill or knowledge in a particular field' or someone who is 'skilful or knowledgeable' (*Collins English Dictionary*). Perhaps the dictionary should also have offered the possibility that an expert is both skilful and knowledgeable. More recently, Gardner (2007: 82), writing about the creating mind, suggests that:

> For every talented writer or composer who breaks new ground, however, hundreds are content – or resigned – to be 'mere' experts. An expert is an individual who, after a decade or more of training, has reached the pinnacle of practice in her chosen domain. The world depends on experts.

Although the world depends on experts, this is still a restricted definition, but nearly everybody is an expert in the art of living in society. Nevertheless, it would be true to say that for a number of years the word 'expert' has fallen into something like disrepute in some parts of the world as terms such as 'competency' have dominated the vocabulary of political correctness in both work and education. But we should not expect people to stop learning just because they have achieved the state of competence – it is a low expectation of achievement in social living, and this should not be an aim in education. We have all been witnesses to this growth of political correctness in UK that downplays the expert, who is better than others, and yet the sum total of every individual's practice is their experience – their expertise – in this or that area of behaviour. We learn our expertise through experiencing and learning from the experience.

> One becomes an expert not simply by absorbing explicit knowledge of the type found in text-books, but through experience, that is, through repeated trials, 'failing, succeeding, wasting time and effort … getting a feel for the problem, learning when to go by the book and when to break the rules'. Human experts gradually absorb 'a repertory of working rules of thumb, or 'heuristics', that combined with book knowledge, make them expert practitioners. This practical, heuristic knowledge, as attempts to simulate it on the machine have shown, is 'hardest to get at because experts – or anyone else – rarely have the self-awareness to recognize what it is. So it must be mined out of their heads painstakingly, one jewel at a time (all quotations from Feigenbaum and McCorduck, 1984).
>
> (Nyiri, 1988: 20–1)

The whole point here is that we just cannot apply theory to practice: the practice situation is a new learning situation and in it we have to find out if the theory can be utilised in any way, but primarily we have to learn from the situation itself. There is no logical connection between *knowing how* and *being able to*. We have to generate our own practical skill and the ensuing knowledge and ultimately our own practical theories (Jarvis, 1999), which may be a combination of book knowledge and what we have learned from the years in practice, often repeating similar manoeuvres and procedures many times but in each learning and reinforcing our learning. It is those years of experience that constitute the basis of expertise, and expertise is specific to the situation – in many cases it may be a generalisable technique that can be replaced by a machine but in others it is specific to the type of situation in which the actor performs.

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As the years go by the experts not only gain knowledge and skills, they might also gain wisdom, but we learn this pre-consciously – and this is one of the fundamental problems in seeking to understand experiential learning. But expertise may not be associated with time in this simple manner because we can repeat behaviours and not learn from them because we do not pay attention to them or to the small differences similar situations have or the slightly different problems each situation poses – only if we treat every experience as an individual learning experience can we gain expertise. Consequently, when we praise someone for their experience we are basically praising them for having continually gained expertise, learned from their experience.

Concluding discussion

From the above discussion, it can be seen that learning is not just a psychological problem, it is a human one, and the study of learning is an existential one. However, we did not start with Descartes' assertion that 'I think, therefore I am'; rather, we reversed it and started with being and the claim that 'I am, therefore I think' or rather, and more accurately, 'I am, therefore I experience', which, in the light of pre-conscious experience, is the more correct claim. Experience, then, is mostly about consciousness

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